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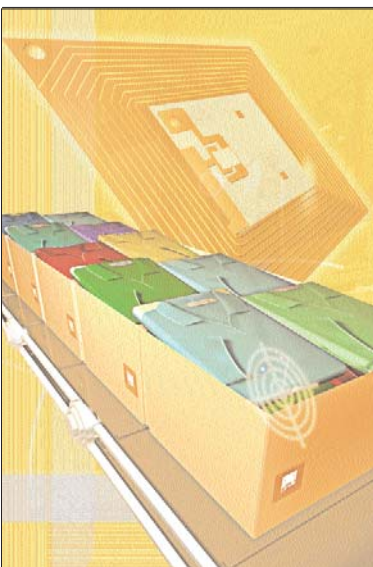
About nine months ago, we deployed RFID technology in asset tracking and calibration of test equipment. Our testing and R&D facilities are set up on a 150-acre site. High-value test equipments constantly move from one location to another within the premises. These are tracked using RFID, so we are aware of exactly what equipment is being used where.

Next is the automatic calibration of engine test equipment. There are sixty varieties of engines that are manufactured—each engine needs a different calibration of the test equipment. As the particular engine moves along the testing line, it is identified by its RFID tag, and the technology integrates with the embedded software in the test equipment to automatically calibrate it for the particular engine.

By April/May of this year, we propose to extend this to the manufacturing line as well. RFID will help in process-based tuning of the Programmable Logic Controllers in the machine tools. Because of this, while the increase in productivity is expected at 10 to 15 per cent, a significant improvement will be in error-proofing, as re-work will come down considerably.

As for the return on investment, a key advantage as opposed to bar code technology is the ability to integrate with the ERP systems.

RFID MAKE SENSE?



Chinara Deshpande
CIO, Pantaloon Retail India

About 10 months ago, at our facilities in Tarapur, we experimented with RFID technology on our John Miller brand of apparel. Since it was a proof-of-concept testing, we tagged only 1,000 units from manufacturing to warehousing. The tags were quite expensive, at Rs 85 per tag. What we learn from the pilot will prove helpful in the future—whenever we deploy on a larger scale.

We discovered that as against the claims of the absence of line-of-sight requirements, the tag readers had to be placed in a “right position.” Errors were caused if this was not adhered to. Also, we had to debug the middleware issues in integrating the data captured with legacy systems. Issues of multiple-reads had to be sorted out. The experiment was also studied from the HR viewpoint, as in the loss of employment.

We discontinued the application after the learning process, and are now in a position to deploy it as and when required. For example, in the future, we may consider extending it to the POS (Point of Sale), but only in premium lifestyle stores: at a Big Bazaar or Food Bazaar, the value of the items stocked does not justify RFID tagging.

Another possible deployment of tags and readers is to track the movement of shopping carts within a store. This will help design store layout keeping customer convenience in mind.



Neeraj Pal Singh
CIO, Madura Garments

We decided on our pilot RFID implementation about a month ago. Going a step ahead of earlier pilots by others in the garments sector, we propose to link up all the way to the POS—the manufacturing unit, the warehouse, and also our Planet Fashion stores in Bangalore.

The advantages over bar code scanning are the labour efficiency that auto-reading offers at the warehouse level, and the elimination of the possibility of imitations at the retail level. Ruggedness is another factor. As far as the investment is concerned, at Rs 30 to 40 per tag, the ability to recycle becomes important.

We plan to go live by mid-April. Our experience with the pilot will form the basis for further decision-making.

As told to Philip Malayil (philip_malayil@thinkdigit.com)